

Communications and Public Relations

Jonathan Oxley, Ph.D.
Department of Public Management and Policy
Andrew Young School of Policy Studies
Georgia State University

PMAP 3210 Chapter 14



Table of Contents

1 Nonprofit PR and Communications

2 Discussion Question

Communications and Public Relations

- Communications

- Organizational communications refers to the process of sending and receiving messages from stakeholders in order for an organization to achieve its goals
- Organizations will employ both external communications, along with internal communications to keep their operation running.

- Public Relations

- External communications could also be classified as “public relations”
- For a more formal definition, Public Relations refer to the the practice of managing the flow of information between an individual or an organization and the public
- Every interaction between the organization and the public falls into public relations
- As such, organizations need to manage their outward presence accordingly – every interaction could be a potential donor’s first impression of the organization

Tools for Nonprofit Communication

- 1 Brochures
- 2 Print / Electronic Newsletter
- 3 Press Releases
- 4 Press Conferences
- 5 Public Service Announcements
- 6 Conferences and Workshops
- 7 Intraorganizational Communication
- 8 Annual Report

Tools for Nonprofit Communications

- 9 Additional Publications
- 10 Member and Board Surveys
- 11 Speakers' Bureaus
- 12 Newspaper Op-Ed Articles
- 13 Letters to the Editor
- 14 Coalitions
- 15 Websites
- 16 Social Media

Format for a Nonprofit Press Release

① Having a good “hook”

- The first sentence needs to get the interested and understand what the press release is about
- The first paragraph needs to answer the 5 W's and 1 H

② Who, What, When, Where, Why, How

- These elements are what you are looking to communicate
- They should be plain and obvious in the first paragraph

③ Inverted Triangle Structure

- Short, clear headline
- Paragraph 1: Summarizes the entire story in one to three sentences
- Paragraph 2: Puts story in context – why it matters
- Paragraph 3: Presents details – who is involved, how it came about, etc
- Paragraph 4: Relevant quotes or additional information to add credibility
- Paragraph 5: More details on how people can get involved

Tips for a Nonprofit Press Release

① Tell a Story

- Each press release presents a story, use this structure to your advantage
- Stories generally follow the “hero’s journey” arch type

② Keep it Simple

- Assume your reader will only read the first paragraph
- Keep paragraphs short (between 30-35 words)
- Avoid going over 1 page

③ Keep it Social and Shareable

- Focus on the target audience for your organization and the program you are putting the release together for
- Make the release as easy to share on social media platforms as humanly possible

④ Build and Maintain Relationships with Journalists

- Journalists will decide whether or not to publish the press release – having a good relationship matters

Basic Elements of a Press Release

- ① When the release can be distributed – FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE
- ② Headline
- ③ Organizational info – Usually to the left below the headline
 - Name of Organization
 - Address
 - Phone Number
 - Website
- ④ Contact info – usually to the right below the headline
 - Name
 - Email address
 - Phone Number
- ⑤ Place, Day, Date – First line
- ⑥ Body of release – paragraphs previously mentioned
- ⑦ Organizational info (boilerplate)
- ⑧ ### – marks centered below content to signal end of release

Table of Contents

1 Nonprofit PR and Communications

2 Discussion Question

Discussion Question

- The text lists several different mediums for nonprofits to communicate with their audience. Regardless of medium, what do you think are the key components of an effective communication strategy for a nonprofit organization, and how can a well-executed public relations plan enhance the organization's mission and impact within the community?